

Newsweek August 2, 2004

iCame, iSaw, iPod



entertainment front.

Excerpts from the article:

Steve Jobs noticed something earlier this year in New York City. "I was on Madison," says Apple's CEO, "and it was, like, on every block, there was someone with white headphones, and I thought, 'Oh, my God, it's starting to happen'."

Jonathan Ive, the company's design guru, had a similar experience in London: "On the streets and coming out of the tubes, you'd see people fiddling with it." And Victor Katch, a 59-year-old professor of kinesiology at the University of Michigan, saw it in Ann Arbor. "When you walk across campus, the ratio seems as high as 2 out of 3 people," he says.

They're talking about the sudden ubiquity of the iPod, the cigarette-box-size digital music player (and its colorful credit-card-size little sister, the Mini) that's smacked right into the sweet spot where a consumer product becomes something much, much more: an icon, a pet, a status indicator and an indispensable part of one's life. To 3 million-plus owners, iPods mean membership into an implicit society that's transforming the way music will be consumed in the future. "When my students see me on campus with my iPod, they smile," says

Professor Katch, whose unit stores everything from Mozart to Dean Martin. "It's sort of a bonding."

Apple wasn't the first company to come out with a player, but the earlier ones were either

low-capacity toys that played the same few songs, or brick-size beasts with impenetrable controls. Apple's device is not only powerful and easy to use, but has an incandescent style that makes people go nuts about it. Or, in the case of 16-year-old Brittany Vendryes of Miami, to dub it "Bob the Music Machine."

(Actor) Will Smith has burred to Jay Leno and Wired magazine about his infatuation with "the gadget of the century." (Actress) Gwyneth Paltrow confided her Pod-love to Vogue (her new baby is named Apple—coincidence?).

People who actually create music are among the biggest fans. Couture maven Karl Lagerfeld's iPod collection is up to 60, coded in the back by laser etching so he can tell what's on them.

To read the entire story, go to <http://snipurl.com/ipodnation>

Wired August 2004

Ross King and His Fantastic Robot



A THINKING MACHINE is the stuff of science fiction. Never, ever, tell that to Ross King. The enigmatic professor of computer science at the University of Wales has devised his own, and this one, says Oliver Morton of *Wired* magazine, promises to change the world.

Excerpts from a brilliant article in one of the world's premier technology publications:

For a machine that's changing the world, the device on the lab bench in front of me doesn't look very impressive—it just goes back and forth, back and forth, back and forth.

A contraption about the size of a human hand moves from side to side along a track. At the far right end of its trajectory, a proboscis-like pipette pecks into a foil-covered plastic container and sucks up some liquid; the hand moves a foot or so to the left, and the pipette squirts out the liquid a few drops at a time onto a rectangular plastic platter covered with an array of 96 tiny depressions. Then it repeats the routine. Whirr, plunge, suck, whirr, plunge, squirt—a mechanical counterpoint to the cries of the seagulls outside the lab in this Welsh coastal town of Aberystwyth.

The effect is oddly hypnotic. Ross King, a professor of computer science at the University of Wales and the Dr. Frankenstein behind this most humdrum of monsters, watches me watching it with a wry amusement that might mask a touch of embarrassment. "It comes across better on radio than on TV," he says.

Indeed, King's robotic lab assistant is something of an ugly duckling. High-throughput screening—testing vast libraries of chemical compounds on various types of cells to see whether they interact in ways that might be useful—has become a routine function in modern bio labs, and at the high end machines that do it are positively telegenic. For instance, the Automation Partnership, based in Royston, England, offers one that bobs, weaves, shakes, and stirs like a possessed bartender. Such uncanny dexterity costs roughly \$1.8 million—but if you're a pharmaceutical company interested in performing as many experiments as quickly as possible, it's money well spent.

King's humble robot is based on a Biomek 2000, a low-rent fluid-handling device that goes for only \$37,900. But it can do something its more nimble cousins can't. Its components—the tireless robot arm, an incubator in which cells cultured on the platter either wither or thrive, and a plate reader that examines the little depressions to see whether anything is growing there—are linked up to a much more exceptional brain. The artificial intelligence routines in that brain can look at the results of an experiment, draw a conclusion about what the results might mean, and then set off to test that conclusion. The "robot scientist" (King has resisted the temptation of a jazzy acronym) may look like a mere labor-saving gizmo, shuttling back and forth ad nauseam, but it's much more than that. Biology is full of tools with which to make discoveries. Here's a tool that can make discoveries on its own.

Read the entire story at <http://snipurl.com/roboticarm>

